부탁의 세기: 누구에게, 얼마나 부드럽게 말해요?

Korean requests range from direct to very soft, depending on the relationship and the size of the favor.

WHAT THIS IS FOR

You can tell how strong a Korean request is and soften it with 혹시, 좀, a cushion phrase, and a question ending.

1 BUILD A SOFT REQUEST, PIECE BY PIECE

1	2	3	4	5
죄송한데요, (Sorry, but... (a cushion before the favor))	**혹시** (by any chance (lowers pressure))	**이 서류 좀** (this document + softener)	**오늘까지 확인해** (check it by today (the action))	**주실 수 있을까요?** (could you possibly...? (soft question ending))

2 FROM DIRECT TO SOFT: ENDINGS AND SOFTENERS

1. **-아/어 줘** (do it for me (casual))
   Very direct. Use it only with family, close friends, or younger people.
   예: 엄마, 휴지 좀 줘.
2. **-아/어 주세요** (please do)
   The standard polite request for shops, staff, and everyday small favors.
   예: 포장해 주세요.
3. **-아/어 주시겠어요?** (would you...?)
   Asks if the person is willing, so it sounds softer than 주세요.
   예: 창문 좀 닫아 주시겠어요?
4. **-아/어 주실 수 있을까요?** (could you possibly...?)
   Very soft. Use it for bigger favors or with a boss, teacher, or client.
   예: 내일까지 보내 주실 수 있을까요?
5. **-아/어 주면 안 돼(요)?** (can't you please...?)
   Sounds like pleading. Use it with close people, not in formal situations.
   예: 오늘만 차 좀 빌려주면 안 돼?
6. **좀** (a little (softener))
   Works like 'please'; it makes almost any request sound less pushy.
   예: 소리 좀 줄여 주세요.
7. **혹시** (by any chance)
   Shows you don't take a yes for granted, so the listener feels free to say no.
   예: 혹시 충전기 있으세요?
8. **죄송한데요** (sorry, but...)
   A cushion phrase before asking a stranger or interrupting someone.
   예: 죄송한데요, 자리 좀 바꿔 주실 수 있어요?

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3 READING TIPS: HOW STRONG DOES IT SOUND?

In Korean, a request usually gets softer as it gets longer and turns into a question. 주세요 is polite, but if you use it to ask a boss or teacher for a big favor, it can sound like an order. For big favors, add 혹시 or 좀 and use 주시겠어요? or 주실 수 있을까요?

The requests on this sheet go from casual to very polite. Choose one based on who you are talking to and how big the favor is.

4 YOUR TURN

READ AND JUDGE REQUESTS

Decide how soft each request is and who it fits, then complete or build the requests.

1 Which request is the softest?
①가방 좀 들어 줘요.
②가방 좀 들어 주실 수 있을까요?
③가방 좀 들어 줘.

2 Is this request OK in the situation? Write Yes or No.
①To your boss: 오늘 보고서 확인해 줘.
②To your younger sister: 리모컨 좀 줘.
③To a stranger on the bus: 죄송한데, 가방 좀 치워 주시겠어요?

3 Fill in each blank with 혹시 or 좀:
①____ 내일 시간 돼요?
②여기에 사인 ____ 해 주세요.

4 Put the pieces in order to make a soft request to a stranger:
주실 수 있을까요? / 죄송한데요, / 사진 좀 / 혹시 / 찍어

5 Make this request softer for a professor. Use -아/어 주실 수 있을까요?:
추천서 좀 써 줘요.

✓ ANSWERS

1) 가방 좀 들어 주실 수 있을까요?
2) ① No ② Yes ③ Yes
3) ① 혹시 ② 좀
4) 죄송한데요, 혹시 사진 좀 찍어 주실 수 있을까요?
5) 추천서 좀 써 주실 수 있을까요? (교수님, 혹시 추천서 좀 써 주실 수 있을까요?)

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